

More than video, games have taken over as a source for entertainment at home. As details in games became better, so did their demand for high-end hardware. As of now, it's not just PC users who enjoy games, but also mobile users and console gamers.

Gamers are known to spend hours and hours on a single game. It's not only high-end games that get us addicted, it's also their lower-end arcade counterparts. Even Solitaire, also known as the game for bored secretaries, can be extremely addictive.

As a whole, digital audio, video and games have converted the simple PC into a complete entertainment centre. And thanks to this, an entire leisure and lifestyle industry has been established, and both manufacturers and buyers are thankful.

The Future

Here's where all this gets more interesting. We all know most of what we've spoken about thus far, but no-one can be truly certain of the technologies that will change our lives in the near future. We're willing to stick our necks out and try and play soothsayer.

Wireless Networking

Although wireless technologies have been around for some time, none have been able to create enough impact to have revolutionised our lives. Yes, we can go to airports and hotels and use our laptops to stay connected, but what happens when you leave those buildings?

In India, true broadband penetration is still a dream—most of us who have always-on “broadband” connections are struggling with speeds that are barely twice or thrice as fast as dial-up. Contrast this with, say, the US or Europe, where broadband means speeds in excess of 512 Kbps.

This is not to say that speeds of 1 Mbps and more are not available in India; it's just that an unlimited access, 1 Mbps plan costs way more than the average worker's salary, and limited MB-based plans, too, are very expensive. Again, compared to the US, where even people living on welfare can afford broadband, India falls far short of expectations. And if those of us living in metros are complaining, imagine the plight of those living in villages and smaller towns.



Wireless technologies have moved us away from our PCs and freed us from the shackles of confinement when computing! Courtesy wireless technologies, we can surf the Net even on a train journey (above)

WiMax, or the wireless technology that succeeds it, could bring hope to remote areas of India—with wireless networks that can cover 10 km using one antenna.

While we cannot deny that it's too expensive to lay fibre optics all over India or set up a nationwide WiMax service, but the passage of time and technology prices are inversely proportional—so chances are prices will fall. The future of broadband penetration could possibly be a mix of fibre optics and wireless solutions.

Alternative Displays

Displays that are flexible, or displays that are projected, will reduce the size of gadgets and their prices as well. Holographic displays could finally give us true 3D viewing pleasure, and although it may sound like something out of *Star Wars*, holographic displays are already becoming a reality.

The reason new display types will change our lives is that for almost a century now, all



Above: The Philips Polymer Vision Readius is an example of just how alternate display technology (paper displays, in this case) can completely re-design the way a device is designed

Below: A concept design by NEC of a device that will use projected displays to do away with both keypads as well as the screen



gadgets that featured the visual element have been 2D. When holographic projection displays finally do become mainstream and affordable, we can be sure that movies, games and images will never have looked so good.

Imagine clicking a picture of your friend, then going home, uploading it to your PC and projecting it. You will actually be able to walk around the image, and look at angles you never saw before. Now picture the Internet; have you ever imagined what a 3D Web site would look like? Actually it's hard to imagine anything, because 2D has been burnt into our brains. Hopefully, we will not need to try imagining for long.